

McMaster Research Ethics Board (MREB)

Jun/18/2026

Principal Investigator: Dr. Spencer Smith

Supervisor:

Student Principal Investigator: Mr Ziyang Fang, Mr. Christopher Schankula

Applicant: Spencer Smith

Project Title: State of the Practice for Scientific Software

MREB#: 8215

Dear Researcher(s),

Thank you for submitting the revised application. I have had the opportunity to review the revisions and have some additional feedback, which is summarized below. Please respond at your earliest convenience by following the instructions below.

Steps to Respond to MREB Ethics Review Comments:

1) Go to question 1.4 in the online application and select “Response to ethics review comments from the MREB Chair”;

2) Revise the Online Form in MacREM;

- Refer to reviewer comments below.
- Navigate to applicable questions within the online form and make the revisions.
- Edits to text fields in the main form should be made within the online interface so the system can track the changes (as opposed to making changes in a Word document and then pasting back into MacREM).

3) Revise Supporting Documents if Required (e.g. Letter of Information, Questionnaire, etc.);

- Use grey highlighting or track changes so the Chair can easily see revisions.
- Upload a PDF version of the revised document(s), with a new version number, at the appropriate place in the application.
- Delete the old version of the document(s) from the application.

4) Summarize the Revisions for the Chair;

- Create a document that lists each reviewer comment (and question number), along with your response to the comment. For guidance, consult the Sample Summary of Revisions document (See Help/Templates in the top menu of MacREM, or click < [here](#) >).
- Use italics, or some other visible formatting, to distinguish your response from the reviewer comments.
- Any changes you make to the application that are in addition to responding to reviewer comments should be explained in the document as well.
- Upload the summary of revisions document to question 1.5 on the form.
- If you think it will be insufficient to use the summary document to address a concern you have with a specific reviewer comment, and that a discussion with the Chair may be necessary, please directly contact the reviewing Chair via email or phone.

5) Once everything is done you can sign the form to resubmit to the Chair.

Following the above steps will make it easier, and therefore faster, for the Chair to review the revisions. For a more comprehensive guide to responding to reviewer comments, see MacREM Quick Guide Respond to REB in Help/Templates or click < [here](#) >.

MREB Comments:

Review Form Comment

Title	Comment
1.4 Please select the status of your application:	When re-submitting your protocol, be sure to select the first item: 'My revised application in response to ethics review comments from the MREB Chair'. You will then be prompted to upload your Summary of Revisions document in 1.5 - the subsequent section.
8.2 Study Purpose/Research Question Description	Very minor comment, but we don't see the indicated change here.
10.6.7 Upload your email script(s) sent directly to participants.	Thank you for clarifying that consent will occur via email. While we understand this approach, we advise that you modify the consent language to strengthen the notion of active consent. So, in paragraph 6 sentence 5, please revise by adding the bracketed text "If you choose to participate in the study, please let me know by [responding to this email and stating that you want to participate in the study. Also, if you have any questions you wanted answered before deciding to participate, please let us know.]"
10.6.7 Upload your email script(s) sent directly to participants.	Please be sure to delete the old versions of the documents uploaded (also commented in section 16)
10.6.12 Upload your appreciation letter/certificate thank you card for participants.	Please include a date regarding withdrawing from the project.
10.6.12 Upload your appreciation letter/certificate thank you card for participants.	Please specify a date regarding withdrawing from the study...before analysis is unspecific.
15.2.2 Describe the administrative purpose(s) for which this information is required.	Don't leave this in your email account.
15.2.2 Describe the administrative purpose(s) for which this information is required.	- We don't see any changes here but the response to chair document notes that 15.2.2. has been modified. Please make those changes in the entry here.
15.11.1 Describe how research data will be collected securely	- We don't see any changes here but the response to chair document notes that 15.11.1 has been modified.
16.6.2 Upload your oral / telephone consent script.	Please be sure to delete the old versions of the documents uploaded (here and in 16.6.3)

If you have any questions or concerns about the review comments, please contact the research ethics office at ethicsoffice@mcmaster.ca or the reviewing Chair.

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Dr. Tara La Rose, MREB Chair

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